PADSHAH-I ISLAM

The kites wheeling into the twisting thermals over Fatehpur Sikri in 1579 would have witnessed a highly unusual sight. Over the smooth red walls of the palace a charpoy was being slowly hoisted up, carrying a Brahmin, one Debi, a theologian and a scholar. The charpoy reached a balcony perched high on the fortress where the Padshah of Hindustan was sitting on a takht, leaning out to listen to the priest. A discussion was had, in which the Brahmin 'instructed [Akbar] in the secrets and legends of Hinduism, in the manner of worshipping idols, the fire, the sun and stars and of revering the chief gods of these unbelievers, such as Brahma, Mahadev, Bishn, Kishn, Ram and Mahama… His Majesty, on hearing further how much the people of the country prized their institutions, began to look upon them with affection.' The writer of these astounding words was Badauni, appalled witness to Akbar's increasing interest in different religions and alternative truths. Badauni also wrote that a Brahmin named Purushottam, a scholar and a translator, had been asked by Akbar to invent Sanskrit names for all things in existence. Abu'l Fazl, reflected more compassionately on Akbar's affection for his Hindu subjects when he wrote about the people of Hindustan in lyrical terms: 'Shall I describe the constancy of its inhabitants or record their benevolence of mind? Shall I portray the beauty that charms the heart or sing of purity unstained? The inhabitants of this land are religious, affectionate, hospitable, genial and frank. They are fond of scientific pursuits, inclined to austerity of life, seekers after justice, contented, industrious, capable in affairs, loyal, truthful and constant.'

Akbar had demonstrated for a long while his affinity and fondness for the people of Hindustan: his long hair, his careful etiquette, his love of Indian tales like the *Panchatantra* and *Singhasan Battisi*, his nurturing of Rajput and other Hindu noblemen, his elimination of discriminatory laws and practices were all manifestations of this fondness. Now, in October 1578, Akbar spoke openly in court of his great love for the people of 'Hind' and 'praised the truth-based nature of the people of India'.

If the manner of Akbar's enquiring into the tenets of Hinduism by suspending a Brahmin on a charpoy was altogether piquant and unusual,